redevelopment and ensuring better living conditions and modern amenities in low-income neighbourhoods.

The objective of consolidating all sections thought to be unhappy with the BJP's social narrative and economic policies is apparent even in the restructuring of the party organisation. The party constitution has been amended to reserve 50 per cent positions at every level for SCs/STs/OBCs/minorities. In both reserved and unreserved categories, 50 per cent of the positions will be earmarked for women and youth (those under the age of 50). The reservation policy will also be applied, though in a curtailed manner, to the elected members of the Congress Working Committee (CWC), the highest decision-making body of the party, which saw its strength increased from 23 to 35.

The BJP makes light of its principal rival's efforts. Most of its senior leaders believe the Narendra Modi government's welfare schemes, such as direct cash transfer, Ujjwala, Jan Dhan accounts and Har Ghar Nal Ka Jal, have created a massive support base of "*labhaarthi*" (beneficiary) voters. The chai-wala-turned-prime minister narrative still has resonance among people across caste, religion, gender or age markers. "What the Congress doesn't understand is that these voters are more loyal than those who vote on religious lines," says a minister in the Modi cabinet.



BHUPESH KESHARWANI

A NEW TONE OF SELF-CONFIDENCE COMES FROM THE BHARAT JODO YATRA, BUT MANY CONTRADICTIONS LINGER

What the Gandhi siblings do realise is that the Congress will gain nothing if the resolutions remain on paper. BJY may have rejuvenated the cadre but, as Rahul said, the Congress now needs to continue with public outreach initiatives. At the end of the plenary, organisational general secretary K.C. Venugopal declared a series of agitational programmes, primarily on the Adani issue, from March 6. More efforts will continue on a "war footing to highlight the BJP government's misrule, anti-democratic and anti-people policies, to quell the atmosphere of hatred, and to bring tangible long-lasting solutions to people's real challenges", promises the Congress resolution.

The fulcrum of these efforts, as Priyanka Gandhi pointed out, will be the grassroots worker. And herein lies the challenge for the Congress. The party has announced it will celebrate the centenary of the Seva Dal, its volunteer unit, to infuse fresh energy into its mass contact programme. That initiative was taken in 2018 as well under Rahul's presidentship, but eventually fizzled out. Great organisational restructure has been promised on paper.

MAHARASHTRA

THE A, B, C, D OF THE DALIT QUOTA

By Dhaval Kulkarni



In what may lead to a churn in Maharashtra politics, Hindu Dalit organisations have launched a stir seeking a division in the quota for scheduled castes (SCs). Currently, SCs get 13 per cent reservations in education and jobs. Hindu Dalit organisations are alleging that the Buddhist Dalits—erstwhile members of the Mahar community who converted to Buddhism with Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar in 1956—have secured most of the benefits from these quotas at the cost of other groups. They believe that ring-fenced categories, or a system of quotas within the larger